themselves of the opprobrium by abolishing an inhuman law they had preached and practiced. There are disturbing indications that European nations are themselves becoming impatient with their vastly more civilized laws. This is to be expected in the face of provocations like the Madrid bombings and last year's July disaster that struck London's subway trains. But isn't that what the terrorists want—to subvert the core of Western democracies?

India has reasons to draw lessons from its own experience with terrorism rather than lean on someone else's methods of handing down retribution. For example, it should ask, how did the state benefit from the hanging of Maqbool Butt in Tihar Jail twenty-two years ago? Butt's appeal against his death sentence was pending since 1976. He was then hanged, suddenly, on a February morning in 1984 and buried within the prison premises. Did the death of this erstwhile leader of JKLF and conspirator in the hijacking of an Indian Airlines plane to Pakistan in 1971 deter eventual violence in Jammu and Kashmir? Did the death of countless others in encounters and in torture chambers help the Indian cause? And what does death mean to the new genre of rebels—the fedayeen? They are there to embrace death anyway, so what can the poor Indian hangman do to deter them?

Deprived of the spirit of Nehru or Gandhi, there is a bloody-mindedness in India today as never before. Television anchors are baying for blood and quick retribution. Right-wing Hindutva hordes are not alone in seeking short-cut methods that override constitutional safeguards promised to an accused. Even after the courts berated the media for carrying Afzal's illegally acquired 'confession', the TV channels are still using the footage to beef up their TRP ratings. The '*desi*' versions leave the avowedly rabid Fox TV way behind in their one-track obsession with consumable terror stories.

Where does all this leave someone like Afzal's wife? All over India, Tabassum wrote in the *Kashmir Times*, people have condemned the attack on Parliament. 'And I agree that it was a terrorist attack and must be condemned. However, it is also important that the people accused of such a serious crime be given a fair trial and their story be fully heard before they are punished. I believe that no one has heard my husband's story and he has so far never been represented in the court properly,' Tabassum's protest note said.

"I appeal to you to hear our story and then decide for yourselves whether justice has been done. Afzal's and my story is the story of many young Kashmiri couples. Our story represents the tragedy facing our people.'[4]